
PAPERBOY

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 26, 2026

Dolly Parton died in Nashville at 80, and the flags come down until Tuesday.

AI

OpenAI's head of data centres walks out mid-buildout

WHAT HAPPENED

Chris Malone, who ran data centres for OpenAI, left last week, [TechCrunch reported](#) on 25 August. He joined in March 2025 after nearly five years at Meta and more than a decade at Google. OpenAI had already reorganised its infrastructure division, moving his reporting line from president Greg Brockman to vice-president Sachin Katti, and says it retains "a strong, deeply experienced data center team". TechCrunch counts thirteen executive departures in 2026 — product chief Fidji Simo and ethics head Chloé Bakalar in July, COO Brad Lightcap and revenue chief Denise Dresser in August. It also reports the IPO has slipped from 2026 to 2027.

WHAT IT MEANS

Compute is OpenAI's entire strategy and its entire cost base. Losing the person who builds it, in the same month the operating and revenue chiefs left, is not ordinary churn. The IPO slip and the exits are probably one story told twice: the buildout is harder than the plan said.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Katti names a replacement, and what OpenAI's next capex commitment looks like beside Oracle's and Microsoft's.

Alibaba's HK\$80bn placement was due to close today. It hasn't said that it did.

WHAT HAPPENED

Alibaba's HK\$80bn (US\$10.2bn) placement — 710 million new shares at HK\$112.70 — was [scheduled to complete on 26 August](#), but no settlement notice had appeared on its filings, on HKEX or on EDGAR by 10:00 UTC. That proves little at this hour — completion notices normally file after the Hong Kong close. The company says 100% of net proceeds go "to invest in its full stack AI capabilities, including to expand and enhance its AI infrastructure." Insiders bought meanwhile: Jack Ma took more than HK\$600m of stock, chairman Joe Tsai HK\$202m across two days and chief executive Eddie Wu about HK\$40m, per [investing.com](#) — single-outlet. Shares closed at HK\$114.20, up 1.51%.

WHAT IT MEANS

The placement knocked 9.5% off the stock on 24 August, and founders buying it straight back is the cheapest available answer to the dilution complaint. It also marks Alibaba doing what the American hyperscalers do: funding AI capex out of the equity market rather than out of cash flow.

WATCH NEXT

The completion notice, and whether Tencent or Baidu follow with raises of their own.

The record labels bought a piece of the company they had been fighting

WHAT HAPPENED

[Stability AI raised a \\$76m Series B](#) on 25 August, taking total funding to \$232m. The investors are Universal Music Group, Sony Music Group, Warner Music Group, Electronic Arts, AMD Ventures and Pacific Alliance Ventures. No valuation was disclosed. UMG and EA had signed co-development deals in October 2025, Warner in November. Chief executive Prem Akkaraju called it "an affirmation of our vision where generative AI empowers every producer, musician, and storyteller." Stability largely prevailed in Getty Images' UK copyright case; US litigation continues.

WHAT IT MEANS

Generative AI's copyright fight is being settled commercially rather than judicially. Three of the four major labels have decided that owning equity in the model beats litigating against it — cheaper than a decade in court, and it buys a seat at the table that no judge was going to grant them.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the remaining US Getty case settles, and whether the labels strike the same arrangement with Suno and Udio.

Nvidia reports tonight, and Asia bought it in advance

WHAT HAPPENED

Nvidia publishes second-quarter FY2027 results after the US close today. Nothing is out yet — [investor relations still shows Q1](#), a record \$81.6bn, up 85% year on year. The company guided to \$91bn plus or minus 2% at roughly 75% gross margin. Sell-side consensus is unsettled: \$91.9bn and \$2.08 a share on one count, Citi's \$93bn on another. Price targets diverge as widely — Oppenheimer \$265, Citi \$300. Asian chip names rallied into it: [the KOSPI closed up 2.03%](#) at 6,880, the Nikkei 225 up 0.59% and the Hang Seng up 0.56%, with Samsung Electronics and SK hynix each about 1% higher.

WHAT IT MEANS

This is the quarter where the AI-capex thesis either clears a raised bar again or doesn't. The October-quarter guide will matter more than the print. The two things worth listening for are memory supply — HBM is the constraint everyone is quietly pricing — and the Vera Rubin ramp schedule.

WATCH NEXT

Release around 20:20 UTC, call after. July PCE lands first, at 08:30 ET this morning; Chair Kevin Warsh gives the Jackson Hole keynote at 10:00 a.m. Friday.

Goldman: China closes two-thirds of its advanced-chip gap by 2035, and no more

WHAT HAPPENED

[Goldman Sachs projects](#) China's advanced-node wafer supply growing at a 46% compound annual rate against 17% demand growth, shrinking the country's advanced-chip deficit from 92% in 2025 to 34% by 2035. That is 410,000 wafers a month of supply against 619,000 of demand. The model assumes SMIC adds 30,000–50,000 advanced-node wafers a month between 2026 and 2031, with yields climbing from 23% this year to 75% by 2035 — still short of the better-than-90% TSMC runs today. Goldman names lithography equipment as the binding constraint. Caixin carried the same note on 25 August.

WHAT IT MEANS

Export controls are working as designed and failing at their stated goal at once. They have not stopped Chinese capacity being built, only made it expensive and low-yielding. A 34% deficit in 2035 is a China that supplies most of its own AI silicon and still imports the best of it.

WATCH NEXT

SMIC's next capex disclosure, and whether any domestic lithography tool reaches production rather than demonstration.

Samsung reported as a broad Vera Rubin supplier — on one outlet's word

WHAT HAPPENED

[Seoul Economic Daily](#) reported on 26 August that Samsung is supplying across Nvidia's Vera Rubin platform: the Groq 3 inference accelerator on a 4nm process at the Pyeongtaek S5 fab, HBM4 for Rubin GPUs, SOCAMM2 low-power memory modules for the Vera CPU, and NAND SSDs. It puts Groq 3 yields above 80%, two to three times April's level, and Pyeongtaek's 4nm line utilisation "approaching 100%". Single outlet, and the yield and utilisation figures carry no attribution — unconfirmed. Nvidia's newsroom did announce on 24 August that Groq 3 LPX is in full production, which is consistent but not corroboration.

WHAT IT MEANS

If it holds, it is the first hard evidence Samsung's foundry has stopped losing to TSMC on the only workload that currently matters. The absence of volumes or revenue is the tell: this is a Korean-press story, not a company disclosure, and the loss-making foundry division badly needs one of those.

WATCH NEXT

Samsung's next foundry segment result, and whether Nvidia confirms a second HBM4 source on tonight's call.

BUSINESS

Oil falls a third session as the war premium drains out

WHAT HAPPENED

Brent traded near \$85.98 and WTI near \$80.08 by 10:00 UTC, both off roughly 3% and down for a third session; WTI's October contract settled at \$82.36 on Tuesday, down 3.1%. The driver is Hormuz diplomacy, not a ceasefire — see World Politics. US markets closed higher on 25 August: [the S&P 500 rose 0.32%](#) to 7,677.28, the Nasdaq Composite 0.66% to 26,151.30 and the Dow 0.30% to 53,577.17. The Conference Board's [consumer confidence index came in at 89.4](#), down 0.8 from a revised 90.2 — a second consecutive month of moderation.

WHAT IT MEANS

Crude has handed back most of its war premium in three sessions. That is the market's verdict on the 24 August sanctions package: severe-looking, built without secondary sanctions on Iran's actual buyers, and read accordingly. Cheaper energy is also the friendliest available backdrop for this morning's inflation print.

WATCH NEXT

July PCE at 08:30 ET. And whether Oman actually announces the shipping corridor it has trailed.

Canada's retaliation is set for 8 September, and still has no published list

WHAT HAPPENED

Canadian counter-tariffs are expected on 8 September, after Washington imposed duties of up to 50% on roughly \$20bn of Canadian goods at 12:01 a.m. ET on 22 August under Section 338 of the Tariff Act of 1930. Ottawa has published no schedule: the finance department's [counter-tariff list was last modified on 19 June](#) and still shows the 2025 rates. [NPR reports](#) planned rates of 15%, 25% and 50% across steel, dairy, appliances, farm equipment, pulp and paper, and electronics. Carney's framing has shifted too: "dollar for dollar" on 22 August became "more targeted retaliation aimed at protecting Canadian workers and businesses" by 24 August. Trump has separately threatened 50% on Canadian vehicles, parts and steel from 1 January 2027 — in a social-media post, not an instrument.

WHAT IT MEANS

The move from matching to targeting is the negotiation, conducted in public. Carney suspended talks rather than ending them, and a narrower list is a smaller thing to climb down from later. The 2027 threat is leverage rather than policy.

WATCH NEXT

8 September, and whether Ottawa publishes goods-level detail first. Also the first court challenge to a statute dormant for decades.

Intuit grew 14%, then guided to 9

WHAT HAPPENED

[Intuit reported fiscal 2026](#) after Tuesday's close: full-year revenue of \$21.4bn, up 14%, with fourth-quarter revenue of \$4.4bn, also up 14%. GAAP diluted earnings were \$16.46 a share, up 20%. Global Business Solutions grew 16% to \$12.9bn and the online ecosystem 19% to \$9.9bn. Then the guide: fiscal 2027 revenue of \$23.3–23.5bn, growth of 9–10%, with GAAP diluted EPS of \$20.12–20.36. Chief executive Sasan Goodarzi described the plan as winning "as an AI-driven expert platform by creating a financial system of intelligence." Zoom, reporting the same afternoon, raised full-year guidance on revenue growth of 4.9%.

WHAT IT MEANS

Fourteen per cent down to nine is a large step for a company whose whole pitch is that AI expands what it can charge for. Intuit is the cleanest public test of whether AI lifts software revenue or only software costs, and this guide says the lift is not visible yet.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the deceleration is tax-season timing or something structural. The January quarter will settle it.

Gatik raises \$200m from Qatar's sovereign fund on the back of a PepsiCo contract

WHAT HAPPENED

Gatik closed a [\\$200m Series D](#) on 25 August, led by the Qatar Investment Authority and KDT, following its driverless delivery contract with PepsiCo. QIA confirmed the round on its own wire. Gatik runs short-haul "middle mile" routes between distribution centres and retail stores rather than long-haul highway freight. No valuation was disclosed.

WHAT IT MEANS

The middle mile is the part of autonomy that actually pencils: fixed routes, low speeds, a named customer with real volume. A sovereign wealth fund leading rather than a venture firm suggests the round is priced as infrastructure with a contracted revenue line, not as a bet on a technical breakthrough still to come.

WATCH NEXT

Whether PepsiCo extends beyond its initial lanes, and what Gatik discloses about driver-out mileage.

Europe's seed money keeps going into professional-services bottlenecks

WHAT HAPPENED

A run of small European rounds landed on 25 August, per tech.eu's index: [Repodo](#), an AI audit startup founded by Lunar's co-founders, raised over €8m; Neno, a Dutch AI-native financial services company, €6.6m; Itoflow, \$2.5m in pre-seed for investment research and portfolio tooling; and Due Dil, which claims to cut venture diligence "from hours to 10 minutes", an undisclosed sum. Separately, Ploughshare's TAG Alliance defence-startup network expanded to 19 members. These are index-level figures and none was independently fetched — confirm before quoting any single one.

WHAT IT MEANS

Every one of these points AI at a billable-hour bottleneck: audit, diligence, research, reporting. That is a rational place for European money to go — expensive professional labour, no domestic hyperscaler to compete with, and buyers who measure value in hours saved rather than in tokens.

WATCH NEXT

Whether any of them discloses revenue rather than headcount at the next round.

Oura still has not filed an S-1

WHAT HAPPENED

A search of [EDGAR](#) returns no matching company for an Oura S-1. The only registration step on record remains the [confidential draft statement submitted on 21 May 2026](#). Bloomberg's report of a raise of up to \$3bn at a valuation above \$16bn, for a September listing, remains unconfirmed by any filing and by any second outlet.

WHAT IT MEANS

A confidential draft can sit for months without becoming anything. Until the S-1 goes public there is no revenue figure, no share count and no float — the \$16bn is a banker's number rather than a market's, and reporting it as a valuation flatters it.

WATCH NEXT

EDGAR. A public S-1 has to land roughly fifteen days ahead of a roadshow, so a September listing needs the filing within days.

US

Dolly Parton dies at 80

WHAT HAPPENED

Dolly Parton died on 25 August at the Vanderbilt-Ingram Cancer Center in Nashville, aged 80. [Her official site](#) said she "died peacefully today in Nashville, Tennessee", giving her dates as 19 January 1946 to 25 August 2026. Her nephew Bryan Seaver said that "after bravely facing a brief battle with cancer, Dolly departed her Earthly life today... surrounded by loved ones." The White House issued [a proclamation the same day](#), "Honoring the Memory of Dolly Parton", ordering flags flown at half-staff until sunset on 1 September.

WHAT IT MEANS

Parton was the rare American figure with no natural opposition — a country institution who was also a gay icon, a songwriter who owned her own publishing when almost no woman in Nashville did, and a philanthropist whose children's book programme outlasted the administrations that praised it. Flags at half-staff for a songwriter is not an ordinary act.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Tennessee announces a state observance, and what becomes of the Imagination Library.

A judge found the administration violated her injunction, then let the rule publish anyway

WHAT HAPPENED

Judge Indira Talwani found on 25 August that the administration had violated her nationwide injunction by finalising the USPS mail-ballot rule — then let it publish anyway. In a five-page decision she wrote that "Defendants cannot contend that they misunderstood the scope of the court's order", and, despite their protestations of taking court orders "very seriously", that "the court finds that Defendants violated the preliminary injunction in this case." She [declined every remedy plaintiffs sought](#), so no sanction followed. It published this morning as "Ballot Mail for Federal Elections", [91 Fed. Reg. 54966](#), effective 21 August — five days before publication. USPS remains barred from implementing it.

WHAT IT MEANS

A finding of violation with nothing attached is one a government can afford. The rule now exists, retroactively, and only an injunction stops it operating. Keep the tracks apart, as most coverage does not: the Supreme Court stayed a separate Talwani ruling on 24 August, but the 11 August nationwide injunction — the one violated here — stands.

WATCH NEXT

Whether plaintiffs move for contempt with teeth this time, and whether the administration seeks a stay of the surviving injunction. First Circuit briefing is pending.

State prepares the largest mass visa revocation on record

WHAT HAPPENED

The State Department is preparing to revoke B1 and B2 visitor visas issued from 2016 to 2026 to people who later filed asylum claims. [The Associated Press](#), which broke it from internal documents and two unnamed officials, puts the internal estimate at up to 200,000; ABC calls it "tens of thousands" with 200,000 a ceiling. Spokesman Tommy Pigott said the department is working with DHS to revoke visas of people who entered "claiming to be short-term visitors, but then file for asylum to stay here permanently." Deputy Secretary Christopher Landau wrote that "asylum isn't supposed to be a loophole to circumvent immigration law." No State release confirms the figures.

WHAT IT MEANS

Filing for asylum is lawful, and revoking the visa of someone already in the process does not remove them — it removes the status they fall back on if the claim fails. The effect is to strip pending applicants of a fallback before any adjudicator has ruled.

WATCH NEXT

A published policy rather than a leak, and the first lawsuit — blanket action of this shape usually draws an Administrative Procedure Act challenge fast.

Oman trails a Hormuz corridor. Tehran says the strait stays shut.

WHAT HAPPENED

Oman's foreign minister Badr Albusaidi and Iran's Abbas Araghchi discussed a phased framework for the Strait of Hormuz: a temporary joint navigation corridor and joint mine-clearing. [Albusaidi said](#) he hoped to "soon announce" the corridor, with a permanent solution to follow "in due course". Tehran spent Wednesday qualifying it: deputy foreign minister Kazem Gharibabadi said the strait "remains closed", and spokesman Esmail Baghaei was explicit that "we are not holding any negotiations with the United States at present." Trump said mines have been cleared from international waters and that any vessel laying new ones will be destroyed — a US claim about a US operation, unverified.

WHAT IT MEANS

Several outlets have called this week's oil slide US-Iran ceasefire talks. It is not. It is Oman brokering shipping access, Pakistan carrying messages, and a sanctions package that spared Iran's buyers; the 17 June memorandum expired on 17 August with nothing replacing it. Note too what has not happened: Treasury's promised designation of a major financial institution — "by the end of this week", Bessent said on 24 August — still has not appeared.

WATCH NEXT

An actual Omani announcement of the corridor, rather than a trailed one. And whether a Chinese bank is ever named.

Ukraine hits a major Russian refinery and a warehouse the size of a district

WHAT HAPPENED

[Ukrainian drones struck the Lukoil-owned Kstovo refinery](#) in Nizhny Novgorod oblast overnight — one of Russia's largest, processing roughly 15 million tonnes a year — and a Wildberries logistics hub at Kotovsk in Tambov oblast, where fire spread across more than 100,000 square metres and deliveries were halted. In Lipetsk oblast a house was hit, killing a man and a 14-year-old. Russia's defence ministry claimed 426 drones intercepted overnight, a figure only it reports. The Ukrainian manufacturer Fire Point says its FP-1 drones struck both sites; Kyiv has not confirmed involvement, so attribution rests on a supplier's claim.

WHAT IT MEANS

Refineries and warehouses, not barracks. Ukraine is attacking the part of the Russian economy ordinary Russians actually meet: fuel queues and undelivered parcels. Kotovsk was hit on 18 July too, pointing either to a deliberate campaign against distribution or to a target within comfortable range.

WATCH NEXT

Whether Kstovo's throughput visibly stops, and Russian retail fuel prices over the next fortnight.

At least 47 killed in a gang attack above Port-au-Prince

WHAT HAPPENED

An armed group attacked Kenscoff, in the hills above Port-au-Prince, on Sunday 24 August. The casualty count was confirmed this week. [At least 47 people were killed](#), including at least five children, with 22 reportedly executed inside a church compound. More than 50 were kidnapped and 25 homes burned. The group is led by a figure known as "Izo 2", said to be coordinating with Johnson André. UN Secretary-General António Guterres said "the relentless gang attacks on communities and the loss of lives underscore the alarming security conditions in Haiti." Haiti's police director has opened an investigation into complicity within the force.

WHAT IT MEANS

Kenscoff is not the neighbourhood where gang control was conceded long ago — it is the hillside where what remains of Port-au-Prince's professional class lives. That the police director is investigating his own officers says more about the Haitian state than the death toll does.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the multinational force in Haiti is reinforced, and whether the Security Council moves on it in September.

SOURCES

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Alibaba Group — placement pricing announcement

TechCrunch — Stability AI raises \$76 million

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Korea Times — Seoul stocks ahead of Nvidia earnings

SCMP — Goldman on China's advanced-chip supply to 2035

Seoul Economic Daily — Samsung as Vera Rubin partner

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Department of Finance Canada — counter-tariff list (last modified 19 June 2026)

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NPR/AP — mass visa revocation of up to 200,000

Al Jazeera — Iran and Oman discuss temporary Hormuz shipping lane

OFAC — recent actions

Kyiv Post — drones strike Kstovo refinery and Wildberries hub

NPR — 47 killed, more than 50 kidnapped in Haiti